

"Some truths
are buried...
but they can
never be forgotten."



THE VILLAGE THAT FORGOT ITS NAME

A JOURNEY OF MEMORY, COURAGE AND THE POWER OF PEOPLE



A STORY BY
HIS-STORY

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Author's Note

The Morning the Drums Went Silent

Before the first rooster crowed, the people of the village usually heard the drums.

Three deep beats.

Boom. Boom. Boom.

They came from the old meeting ground beneath the enormous odum tree, where the village drummer sat every morning and announced the beginning of a new day.

The first beat meant, *Wake up.*

The second meant, *The day has arrived.*

The third meant, *Remember who you are.*

At least, that was what Ikenna's grandmother had always told him.

But on that particular morning, there was no drum.

Ikenna woke suddenly.

He sat upright on his mat and listened.

Nothing.

Not the drum.

Not the usual footsteps outside.

Not even the cheerful voice of his mother, Chioma, calling him to help with the morning chores.

The silence felt strange.

Too strange.

Ikenna slipped out of bed and stepped outside.

A thin mist covered the village. The roofs of the houses appeared like dark shapes beneath the pale morning sky.

Then he saw Chinedu running toward him.

"Ikenna!"

"What happened?"

Chinedu stopped to catch his breath.

"The village drum."

"What about it?"

"It is gone."

Ikenna frowned.

"The drum cannot be gone. Eze keeps it in the meeting house."

"I know. That's why I'm telling you."

They hurried toward the meeting ground.

As they approached, Ikenna noticed something even stranger.

The old wooden sign that stood at the entrance of the village had fallen onto the ground.

Ikenna and Chinedu bent over it.

The letters carved into the wood were gone.

Not scratched out.

Not covered.

Gone.

The surface was perfectly smooth, as though nobody had ever carved anything there.

Chinedu stared at it.

"Who did this?"

"I don't know."

Ikenna touched the wood.

A cold feeling travelled through his fingers.

Behind them, footsteps approached.

It was Atine, the oldest elder in the village.

She stared at the sign for a long moment.

Then she whispered,

"Something is wrong."

“What is the name of our village?” Ikenna asked.

Atine opened her mouth.

Nothing came out.

She looked at him.

Then at Chinedu.

Then back at the sign.

“I...”

Her voice trembled.

“I don't remember.”

Ikenna laughed nervously.

·Atine, you're joking.·

But the old woman did not smile.

She looked frightened.

Soon, other villagers gathered around them.

The chief came.

The elders came.

The blacksmith came.

The storyteller came.

Everyone stared at the blank wooden sign.

And then something happened that frightened Ikenna more than anything else.

One by one, the villagers began asking the same question.

“What is the name of our village?”

Nobody knew.

Then, from somewhere beyond the trees, came the sound of a single drumbeat.

BOOM.

Everyone turned toward the forest.

A second beat followed.

BOOM.

Then a third.

BOOM.

Ikenna looked at Chinedu.

The missing village drum was supposed to be inside the meeting house.

So who was playing it?

And why did it sound as if the drum was calling them from the forest?

At that moment, an unfamiliar man stepped out from between the trees.

He wore a long, dusty cloak and carried an old walking stick.

He stopped several steps away from the villagers.

Then he smiled.

“Finally,” he said quietly.

“The village has forgotten.”

Chapter Two

The Stranger in the Forest

Nobody moved.

The mysterious man stood at the edge of the forest, his walking stick planted firmly in the earth.

Ikenna felt Chinedu's hand grip his arm.

"Who is that?" Chinedu whispered.

"I don't know."

The chief, Chukwudi, stepped forward.

"Stranger," he called, "who are you?"

The man smiled.

"My name is Abanga."

"Where did you come from?"

Abanga turned and looked into the forest.

"From a place your people once knew."

A murmur passed through the crowd.

Chief Chukwudi's expression hardened.

"This is no time for riddles. Our village has lost its name. Tell us what you know."

Abanga slowly lifted his walking stick and pointed toward the blank wooden sign.

"You have not lost your name."

Everyone became silent.

"You have **forgotten** it."

Atine stepped forward.

"What is the difference?"

Abanga looked directly at her.

“The difference between losing something and forgetting it is that what is lost can be found.”

He paused.

“But what is forgotten must first be remembered.”

Ikenna felt a strange chill.

“What do you mean?” he asked.

Abanga looked at him.

For several seconds, he said nothing.

Then he replied,

“You are the one who must ask that question.”

Before Ikenna could respond, a voice came from the crowd.

It was Ama.

“Why should we trust you?”

Abanga's smile disappeared.

“You shouldn't.”

The villagers murmured again.

Ama folded her arms.

“Then why are you here?”

Abanga looked toward the forest.

“Because someone has begun taking your memories.”

A gasp came from the crowd.

Chief Chukwudi stepped closer.

“Who?”

Abanga shook his head.

“That is the question you must answer before the sun sets.”

“Why before sunset?” the chief demanded.

Abanga looked at the sky.

"Because when darkness comes, the forgetting will spread."

Nobody spoke.

Then Emeka, the village storyteller, suddenly held his head.

"I remember something," he said.

Everyone turned toward him.

Emeka's eyes widened.

"A story."

"What story?" Atine asked.

"I don't know."

He frowned.

"I can remember the beginning, but not the end."

"Tell us the beginning," said Ikenna.

Emeka closed his eyes.

"Long ago, before the houses were built..."

He stopped.

His face became pale.

"I can't remember what happened next."

Then the village blacksmith, Eze, suddenly shouted.

"My workshop!"

He ran away.

"What happened?" Chinedu asked.

Eze returned moments later carrying an old iron box.

"There was something written on this."

He turned the box around.

A sentence had been scratched into the metal.

But only three words remained.

REMEMBER THE ROOTS.

Ikenna stared at the words.

Then he noticed something else.

A small symbol had been carved beneath them.

It looked like an eye surrounded by twelve tiny circles.

Abanga saw it too.

His face changed.

For the first time, he looked afraid.

“Where did you get that?” he asked.

Eze pointed toward his workshop. Awini, the chief’s adviser, watched the box closely.

“It has been there for generations.”

Abanga stepped backward.

“Then it has begun.”

“What’s begun?” Ikenna asked.

Abanga looked at him.

“The search for the forgotten name.”

Suddenly—

BOOM!

The village drum sounded from the forest again.

Everyone turned.

Abanga tightened his grip on his walking stick.

“Nobody goes into the forest.”

Ikenna looked at Chinedu.

Chinedu looked back at him.

Neither of them said a word.

But both were thinking the same thing.

If the missing drum was calling from the forest...

they had to find it.

And before the night arrived, they would discover that the forgotten name of their village was only the beginning.

Chapter Three

Into the Forest

The sun was already climbing when Ikenna and Chinedu slipped away from the meeting ground.

They had waited until the villagers became distracted by the argument between Chief Chukwudi and the elders.

Nobody had noticed them leave.

At least, that was what they hoped.

The forest stood beyond the last row of houses, thick and green beneath the morning light.

Ikenna stopped at its edge.

“Are you sure about this?”

Chinedu swallowed.

“No.”

Ikenna smiled.

“Good. At least we're both foolish.”

Chinedu laughed quietly.

Then they stepped beneath the trees.

Immediately, the sounds of the village disappeared.

No voices.

No chickens.

No children playing.

Only the rustling of leaves above them.

They followed the sound of the drum.

BOOM.

They stopped.

The sound seemed close.

BOOM.

But when they moved toward it, it suddenly sounded farther away.

"That's strange," Chinedu whispered.

Ikenna nodded.

They continued.

After several minutes, they discovered something lying beneath a large tree.

It was a piece of the village drum.

The leather covering had been torn away, leaving the wooden frame exposed.

Chinedu picked it up.

"This is Eze's drum."

Ikenna examined the wood.

There were strange marks carved into it.

The same symbol they had seen on Eze's iron box.

An eye surrounded by twelve circles.

"What does it mean?" Chinedu asked.

Before Ikenna could answer, they heard footsteps.

Someone was coming.

They quickly hid behind a fallen tree.

A figure walked between the trees.

It was Ama.

She stopped beside the broken drum.

Then she looked around carefully.

"I know you're here," she said.

Ikenna's heart jumped.

Chinedu covered his mouth.

Ama continued.

"You shouldn't have followed the drum."

She reached into her cloth bag and pulled out a small, old piece of parchment.

She unfolded it.

For a moment, her face showed fear.

Then she whispered,

"Not again."

Ikenna could no longer remain hidden.

"What does that mean?"

Ama spun around.

Her eyes widened.

"You!"

Chinedu stepped out behind Ikenna.

Ama quickly folded the parchment.

"Go back to the village."

"We want answers," Ikenna said.

"You don't understand what you're looking for."

"Then explain it."

Ama looked toward the deeper part of the forest.

"The drum isn't calling you."

Ikenna frowned.

"Then who is?"

Ama's voice became almost a whisper.

"The village itself."

A sudden wind swept through the trees.

The leaves shook violently.

Then, from somewhere deep in the forest—

BOOM.

The three of them froze.

Another beat followed.

BOOM.

Then the third.

BOOM.

Ama looked terrified.

“The old signal,” she whispered.

“What signal?” Chinedu asked.

Ama did not answer.

Instead, she turned toward the sound.

“We have to leave.”

But before they could move, something appeared between the trees.

A narrow stone path.

Ikenna was certain it had not been there moments earlier.

At the end of the path stood a weathered wooden door.

And carved across the door were five words:

WHAT WAS FORGOTTEN WAITS BELOW.

Ikenna stared at the inscription.

Then he heard a voice behind them.

“Now you know why I told you not to enter the forest.”

They turned.

Abanga stood among the trees.

And this time, he was not smiling.

The Door Beneath the Trees

For a long moment, nobody spoke.

The wooden door stood silently at the end of the stone path.

Ikenna stepped closer.

“What's behind it?”

Abanga's eyes remained fixed on the door.

“Something your ancestors tried very hard to keep hidden.”

Ama shook her head.

“You shouldn't have brought us here.”

Abanga looked at her.

“I didn't bring them.”

He pointed toward Ikenna and Chinedu.

“They followed the drum.”

Chinedu frowned. “Then why did the drum lead us here?”

“Because someone wanted you to find this place.”

Ikenna looked at the inscription again.

WHAT WAS FORGOTTEN WAITS BELOW.

“Who?”

Abanga didn't answer.

Instead, he walked to the door and placed his hand against the wood.

Nothing happened.

He tried pushing it.

The door didn't move.

Then Ama noticed something.

“There.”

She pointed to the ground.

A small stone had been set into the earth beside the doorway. It had the same symbol as the drum and Eze's iron box—the eye surrounded by twelve circles.

Ikenna crouched beside it.

There was writing underneath.

He brushed away the dirt.

Three words appeared:

TWELVE MUST REMEMBER.

“Remember what?” Chinedu asked.

A deep sound suddenly came from beneath their feet.

BOOM.

The ground trembled.

Ama stepped backward.

“The first bell.”

Ikenna looked at her.

“Bell?”

Before she could explain, Abanga suddenly grabbed his arm.

“Run!”

They raced back along the stone path.

Branches whipped against them as they hurried through the forest.

Behind them came another sound.

Not a drum this time.

A bell.

GONG.

Then another.

GONG.

Then another.

GONG.

Ikenna looked back.

The wooden door was slowly opening.

But nobody was touching it.

Darkness filled the doorway.

And standing inside that darkness was a figure.

Tall.

Completely still.

Watching them.

Chinedu stumbled.

“Ikenna...”

“I see him.”

The figure raised one hand.

Then pointed directly at Ikenna.

A voice travelled through the forest.

“You have remembered the path.”

Ikenna froze.

The figure spoke again.

“Now you must remember the name.”

Then the door slammed shut.

BOOM!

The forest became silent.

Abanga stared at Ikenna.

"What did it say?"

Ikenna swallowed.

"I don't know."

Ama slowly shook her head.

"I think you do."

Ikenna looked at her.

"What?"

She pointed toward his hand.

The stone they had found beside the door was there.

He didn't remember picking it up.

And on its surface, new words had appeared:

THE NAME HAS BEEN FORGOTTEN.

Ikenna's heart began pounding.

If the village's true name had been forgotten...

then what was?

The Name Hidden in Stone

Ikenna stared at the words on the stone.

THE NAME HAS BEEN FORGOTTEN.

“Then what is?” he asked.

Nobody answered.

The forest seemed to hold its breath.

Abanga walked toward Ikenna and carefully took the stone from his hand.

“This is older than the village.”

Ama's eyes narrowed.

“How old?”

“Older than any living person.”

Chinedu looked around nervously.

“Can we please discuss this somewhere that doesn't have mysterious doors and talking shadows?”

Nobody laughed.

Abanga turned the stone over.

On its underside was a tiny carving.

A circle.

Inside the circle was a single letter.

A.

Ama immediately recognized it.

“Akanma.”

The word seemed to awaken something in the air.

Ikenna repeated it slowly.

“Akanma.”

The moment he said the name, the forest wind stopped.

Then—

BOOM!

A drum sounded somewhere beyond the trees.

This time, it sounded different.

Not threatening.

Almost welcoming.

Ikenna suddenly remembered something.

A woman's voice.

His grandmother's voice.

He had heard the same name when he was very young.

“Akanma,” he whispered.

Abanga's expression changed.

“You remember.”

“I've heard it before.”

“Where?”

Ikenna closed his eyes.

“My grandmother used to tell me that our village had another name.”

Ama stepped closer.

“What did she tell you?”

“She said the name was supposed to be remembered by every child.”

“Why?”

Ikenna opened his eyes.

“She never told me.”

A crack suddenly appeared in the stone.

Everyone stepped back.

The letter **A** began glowing faintly.

Then the stone split into two pieces.

Inside was a tiny rolled piece of leather.

Ama carefully picked it up and opened it.

There was only one sentence written on it:

WHEN THE NAME IS FORGOTTEN, FIND THE KEEPER.

Chinedu frowned.

“Who is the Keeper?”

Abanga looked toward the village.

“I was hoping we wouldn't have to find him.”

Ikenna's stomach tightened.

“Why?”

Abanga's voice became quiet.

“Because the last Keeper disappeared twenty years ago.”

“And you knew him?”

Abanga hesitated.

“Yes.”

“Who was he?”

Before Abanga could answer, a woman's voice echoed from behind them.

“I know who he was.”

They turned.

It was Ngozi, Ikenna's grandmother.

She stood at the edge of the trees, holding an old wooden box against her chest.

Ikenna ran toward her.

“Grandmother, what are you doing here?”

Ngozi looked at the stone.

Then at Abanga.

Her face became pale.

“You found the door.”

Abanga lowered his head.

Ngozi whispered,

“Then there is very little time left.”

She opened the wooden box.

Inside lay an ancient bronze key.

On the handle was the same symbol—

an eye surrounded by twelve circles.

Ngozi looked directly at Ikenna.

“Your grandfather told me never to give this to anyone.”

She placed the key in his hand.

“But he also told me that one day, you would need it.”

Ikenna stared at the key.

“What does it open?”

Ngozi looked toward the dark forest.

“The place where Akanma buried its first secret.”

Then the bronze key began to tremble in Ikenna's hand.

And somewhere beneath the earth...

a lock clicked.

The Chamber Beneath the Village

The click came again.

Click.

Ikenna stared at the bronze key.

“Did you hear that?”

Ngozi nodded.

“The earth has opened its door.”

Chinedu took a cautious step backward.

“I don't like the sound of that.”

Ama looked at Abanga.

“You knew this would happen.”

Abanga said nothing.

Ngozi walked toward a huge tree whose roots rose from the ground like the walls of a small room.

She pushed aside a curtain of vines.

Behind them was a narrow opening in the earth.

A stone staircase descended into darkness.

Ikenna's heart began to race.

“How long has this been here?”

“Longer than the village itself,” Ngozi replied.

Abanga lit a small lantern.

“Stay close. Whatever happens, don't touch anything.”

They descended.

The air became colder with every step.

The walls were covered with carvings—people carrying baskets, farmers working in fields, children learning beside elders, and great gatherings beneath an enormous tree.

Then Ikenna noticed something unusual.

Every person in the carvings had a small circle above their head.

Except one.

A man standing alone at the centre had **twelve circles** around him.

“Who is that?” Ikenna asked.

Ngozi stopped.

“That is the Keeper.”

“Who was he?”

Ngozi looked at Abanga.

Abanga finally spoke.

“His name was Atiah.”

The name echoed through the passage.

Atiah... Atiah... Atiah...

Suddenly, the lantern went out.

Chinedu grabbed Ikenna.

“Something touched me!”

“Nobody move,” Abanga said.

A faint light appeared ahead.

They continued carefully until they reached a massive underground chamber.

At its centre stood a stone table.

On the table was a sealed clay pot.

Twelve symbols surrounded it.

And beneath them were twelve names.

Ikenna stepped closer.

He recognized one immediately.

ATINE.

Then another.

EZE.

Then another.

EMEKA.

These were not just ancient names.

They were names still carried by people in their village.

“The Keepers,” Ngozi whispered.

Ikenna looked at her.

“Are the people in our village descendants of them?”

“Some are.”

“Then why did we forget?”

Nobody answered.

A slow sound came from behind them.

Tap.

Everyone turned.

Tap.

Someone was walking down the staircase.

A shadow appeared on the wall.

Then a familiar voice spoke.

“You should never have opened the chamber.”

Ikenna recognized the voice immediately.

It was **Awini**, the chief’s adviser.

He stepped into the chamber.

And in his hand was a second bronze key.

Awini looked at the clay pot.

His eyes filled with hunger.

“After all these years...”

Abanga stepped between him and the table.

“Don’t.”

Awini’s expression hardened.

“You’ve spent years hiding this from everyone.”

“I was protecting them.”

“By keeping them ignorant?”

Abanga’s eyes narrowed.

“By keeping something dangerous out of the wrong hands.”

Awini laughed bitterly.

“Then perhaps it is time the right hands took it.”

He raised the key.

The chamber suddenly shook.

A crack appeared across the clay pot.

Everyone froze.

From inside came a faint whisper.

“Who has awakened me?”

The pot began to glow.

And the twelve symbols around the chamber lit up—one after another.

Then the thirteenth symbol appeared.

The Voice in the Clay

The thirteenth symbol continued to glow.

Ikenna could hardly breathe.

“There are only twelve Keepers,” Ngozi whispered.

“Then why is there a thirteenth symbol?” Chinedu asked.

Nobody answered.

The clay pot trembled on the stone table.

Crack.

A thin line spread across its surface.

Awini stepped forward.

“Move aside.”

Abanga blocked him.

“No.”

Awini's expression hardened.

“You've spent years hiding this from everyone.”

“You don't understand what you're dealing with.”

Awini laughed bitterly.

“Then tell me.”

Abanga's eyes remained fixed on the pot.

Before he could answer, every flame in the chamber went out.

Darkness swallowed them.

Then a voice filled the room.

Not loud.

Not angry.

But old.

Very old.

“You came looking for what was forgotten.”

Ikenna felt the hairs on his arms rise.

“Who are you?” he asked.

The voice answered:

“I am what your people buried.”

The stone floor began to vibrate.

Images appeared across the walls.

Ikenna saw the village as it had been hundreds of years earlier.

People gathered beneath the great tree.

Children listened to elders.

Farmers shared seeds.

Craftsmen taught apprentices.

And twelve people stood apart from the crowd.

Each carried the symbol of the Keeper.

Then the image changed.

The village was burning.

People were running.

Strangers were entering through the gates.

The twelve Keepers gathered around the same clay pot.

A young man stood among them.

Ikenna recognized him immediately.

It was Atiah.

But he looked nothing like the frightening figure Ikenna had imagined.

He looked young.

Afraid.

And desperate.

Atiah held the clay pot against his chest.

The image changed again.

The village was peaceful.

But the people had forgotten something.

Their old songs.

Their agreements.

Their stories.

Their history.

Ikenna stared in shock.

“Atiah did this?”

The voice answered.

“He believed forgetting would protect them.”

Ngozi lowered her head.

“And it didn’t.”

“No,” said the voice.

“Because a people who forget their past become easy to control.”

Awini stepped forward.

“Then give me the knowledge.”

The voice fell silent.

Awini raised the bronze key.

“I have searched for this chamber for years.”

Abanga suddenly moved.

“Awini, don’t!”

But Awini turned the key toward the clay pot.

Before he could touch it, the thirteenth symbol flashed.

The key flew from his hand.

It struck the stone floor.

CLANG!

Then the clay pot split open.

A cloud of golden dust rose into the air.

Ikenna coughed and covered his face.

Within the golden cloud, hundreds of tiny images appeared.

Names.

Faces.

Places.

Stories.

Memories.

They moved around the chamber like stars.

Then one image stopped directly in front of Ikenna.

It showed a young woman holding a baby.

The woman looked exactly like Ngozi.

Ikenna turned toward his grandmother.

“Who is that?”

Ngozi's eyes filled with tears.

“My mother.”

Ikenna stared at the image.

“I've never seen her.”

“You weren't supposed to.”

“Why?”

Ngozi looked at the golden memories.

“Because some memories were taken from us.”

The voice spoke again.

“And now they are returning.”

Suddenly, somewhere far above them, the village drums began to beat.

Boom.

Boom.

Boom.

Ikenna looked at the others.

The forgotten memories were awakening.

But the voice had one final warning.

“When the last memory returns, the village must choose what to do with the truth.”

The chamber fell silent.

Then the stone wall behind the clay pot slowly opened.

Beyond it was a narrow staircase leading even deeper underground.

And carved above the entrance were four words:

THE TRUTH WAITS BELOW.

The Secret Beneath the Stones

Ikenna stared at the staircase.

It disappeared into darkness.

No one moved.

Then Chinedu whispered, "We are really going down there, aren't we?"

Ikenna looked at him.

"We've already come this far."

Chinedu sighed.

"That's exactly what people say before trouble finds them."

Ama almost smiled.

"Then stay here."

"Absolutely not."

They began descending.

The staircase was narrow, and the walls seemed to grow older with every step. Strange symbols covered the stones, but none of them could understand what they meant.

After a while, they reached another chamber.

Unlike the first one, this chamber was completely empty.

Except for a large stone basin in the centre.

Ikenna approached it.

Inside the basin was water.

Perfectly still.

He leaned over it.

Instead of seeing his reflection, he saw the village.

But it wasn't the village as it looked now.

It was the village from many years ago.

He saw people gathering beneath the great tree.

He saw children learning from elders.

He saw the twelve Keepers standing together.

Then the image changed.

A group of strangers approached the village.

They carried weapons and demanded that the villagers reveal where their most important records were kept.

The villagers refused.

The strangers became angry.

Then Atiah stepped forward.

He held the bronze bell.

Ikenna watched as Atiah made a terrible decision.

He rang the bell.

GONG.

A strange wind swept through the village.

The strangers suddenly forgot why they had come.

But so did some of the villagers.

Ikenna stepped away from the basin.

“That's what happened.”

Ngozi nodded sadly.

“Atiah discovered that the bell could affect memory.”

“And he used it on his own people.”

“At first, he believed he was protecting them.”

Ikenna looked at the image.

“But he went too far.”

“Yes.”

A quiet voice came from behind them.

“Fear often begins as protection.”

Everyone turned.

Abanga stood at the entrance.

Ikenna frowned.

“You knew about this.”

Abanga nodded.

“I did.”

“Then why didn't you tell us?”

Abanga looked down.

“Because I was afraid.”

“Afraid of what?”

“Of what would happen if people learned the truth.”

Ama stepped forward.

“And did keeping silent make things better?”

Abanga didn't answer.

Suddenly, the water in the basin began to move.

The image disappeared.

A message appeared on the surface.

THE KEEPER WAS NOT THE ONLY ONE WHO MADE A CHOICE.

Then another line appeared.

ONE OF THE TWELVE BETRAYED THE OTHERS.

Everyone stared at the message.

“Who?” Chinedu asked.

The water went completely still.

Then a name appeared.

AWINI.

Silence filled the chamber.

Ikenna's eyes widened.

“Awini?”

Ama shook her head.

“No. That can't be right.”

Abanga looked troubled.

“The chamber doesn't lie.”

A loud sound suddenly echoed from above.

GONG!

Then another.

GONG!

The entire underground passage began shaking.

Dust fell from the ceiling.

Ngozi grabbed Ikenna's arm.

“We have to leave.”

But before they could move, the stone doorway behind them slammed shut.

They were trapped.

Then a final message appeared in the basin:

THE BETRAYER IS ALREADY AMONG YOU.

Ikenna slowly turned toward the others.

Nobody spoke.

But for the first time, he wondered whether the danger had really been beneath the village...

or whether it had been standing beside them all along.

The Betrayer

The chamber remained silent.

The name **AWINI** seemed to hang in the air.

Ikenna looked at Ama.

Then at Abanga.

Then at his grandmother.

“How could Awini betray the Keepers?”

Ngozi shook her head.

“We don’t know the whole story.”

“But the chamber named him.”

“Yes,” Abanga said. “But a name can tell you who made a choice. It does not always tell you why.”

A loud crack came from the stone doorway.

Everyone turned.

The door was beginning to open.

Through the narrow gap came a faint orange light.

Someone was approaching.

Ikenna held his breath.

A shadow appeared.

Then Awini stepped into the chamber.

He was holding the bronze key.

His clothes were covered with dust, and his face looked exhausted.

“You found the chamber,” he said.

Ikenna stepped forward.

“The stone says you betrayed the Keepers.”

Awini froze.

For several seconds, he said nothing.

Then he slowly lowered his head.

“It is true.”

Ama stared at him.

“Why?”

Awini looked at the stone basin.

“I wanted the knowledge.”

“What knowledge?”

“Everything.”

He walked closer.

“The history of our people. Their medicines. Their farming methods. Their agreements with neighbouring villages. The locations of old water sources. Every secret our ancestors had preserved.”

Chinedu frowned.

“Why would you need all that?”

Awini's eyes hardened.

“Because knowledge gives people power.”

Abanga shook his head.

“That's what Atiah believed.”

Awini looked at him.

“And look what happened to him.”

A sudden silence followed.

Awini continued.

“I searched for this chamber because I believed the Keepers had hidden something that could make our village stronger.”

Ikenna asked, “And what did you plan to do with it?”

Awini looked directly at him.

"I wanted to control it."

Ama stepped forward.

"And that is exactly why the Keepers hid it."

Awini's expression changed.

"You don't understand."

"Then explain."

Awini took a deep breath.

"My father died believing our village had lost too much. Our traditions were disappearing. Our young people stopped listening to the elders. I thought if I possessed the knowledge, I could force everyone to respect it."

Ikenna stared at him.

"You wanted to control people so they would remember."

Awini looked away.

"Yes."

Ngozi spoke quietly.

"You cannot force people to value their history by taking away their freedom."

Awini's eyes lowered.

"I know that now."

The chamber suddenly trembled.

The stone basin cracked.

A deep voice echoed from beneath the floor.

"The betrayer has confessed."

Everyone froze.

The voice continued.

"But confession is not the end."

A section of the floor opened.

Beneath it was a small wooden chest.

Ikenna approached it.

On its lid were three words:

THE LOST NAME.

He looked at the others.

Then slowly reached for the chest.

The moment his fingers touched it—

every bell in the underground chamber began ringing.

And from inside the chest came a whisper:

“Akanma.”

The Lost Name

The word echoed through the chamber.

Akanma.

Ikenna stared at the wooden chest.

“That's the name.”

Ngozi nodded slowly.

“The name your people forgot.”

Chinedu looked at the chest.

“Then open it.”

Ikenna lifted the lid.

Inside was a single piece of dark cloth wrapped around a small wooden tablet.

He unfolded the cloth.

The tablet was covered in writing.

At the top were the words:

AKANMA — THE PLACE WHERE MEMORY LIVES.

Ikenna read the words aloud.

The moment he finished, the chamber shook.

Images appeared on the walls.

He saw the first people who had settled there.

They had arrived after a long journey, carrying seeds, tools, water and the stories of their ancestors.

An old woman stood before them.

She placed her hand on the earth and said:

“A village is more than houses. It is the memory of the people who build them.”

The image changed.

Years passed.

Children became elders.

Elders became ancestors.

But the name **Akanma** remained.

Until Atiah discovered the power of the bronze bell.

Ikenna watched as fear slowly changed him.

Atiah began hiding records.

Then he began deciding which memories people should keep.

Finally, he used the bell to make the village forget.

Ikenna clenched his fists.

“He didn’t protect the village.”

“No,” Abanga said quietly.

“He protected his own idea of the village.”

Suddenly, another image appeared.

Atiah stood before twelve Keepers.

One of them was Awini’s ancestor.

Another was Abanga’s.

Atiah held the bronze bell.

“I have made a mistake,” he said.

Then he handed the tablet to the Keepers.

“One day, someone will have to restore what I took away.”

The image disappeared.

Ikenna looked at Abanga.

“You knew.”

"I knew part of it."

"Why didn't you tell us?"

Abanga looked ashamed.

"Because I was one of the people who helped Atiah."

The chamber went silent.

Chinedu stepped backward.

"You?"

Abanga nodded.

"I believed him. I believed fear was a good enough reason to hide the truth."

He looked at the tablet.

"I was wrong."

The voice beneath the chamber spoke again.

"The name has been found."

The stone walls began glowing.

"But a name alone cannot restore a people."

Ikenna looked around.

"Then what can?"

The voice answered:

"The truth must be carried by those who are willing to share it."

The wooden tablet suddenly became warm in Ikenna's hands.

A new sentence had appeared beneath the name:

REMEMBER. SHARE. TEACH.

Then the chamber doors opened.

Beyond them was a passage leading toward the surface.

But before anyone could leave, Ikenna heard something.

A faint sound.

Gong.

He stopped.

Another bell answered from somewhere far beyond the village.

Gong.

Ikenna looked at Ngozi.

“Did you hear that?”

She shook her head.

“No.”

Ikenna looked toward the darkness.

Whatever had been awakened beneath Akanma...

it was not finished with them yet.

Chapter Eleven

The Final Choice

The passage climbed steadily toward the surface.

Nobody spoke.

Ikenna carried the wooden tablet against his chest. The name **AKANMA** was still clearly carved across it.

When they finally emerged from the forest, the sun was beginning to set.

But the village was not as they had left it.

People stood in the streets, confused and frightened.

Some were calling out the names of relatives they had suddenly remembered.

Others were opening old boxes, searching through forgotten belongings.

Chief Chukwudi saw them and hurried forward.

“What happened?”

Ikenna held up the tablet.

“We found the name.”

The chief stared at it.

Then, almost as if a door had opened inside his mind, his eyes widened.

“Akanma.”

Atine stepped forward.

“Akanma...”

She began to cry.

“I remember.”

The villagers gathered around.

Ikenna raised his voice.

“Our village was never supposed to forget its name.”

He told them everything.

The hidden chamber.

The Keepers.

Atiah's mistake.

The bronze bell.

The memories that had been taken.

And Awini's confession.

When he finished, nobody spoke.

Then Awini stepped forward.

"I was wrong," he said.

"I thought controlling our history would protect it. Instead, I nearly destroyed the very thing I wanted to preserve."

Chief Chukwudi looked at him for a long time.

Then he said,

"A leader who cannot admit his mistake will make the same mistake twice."

Awini lowered his head.

Ikenna looked at the villagers.

"We have a choice now."

Everyone listened.

"We can choose one person to keep all this knowledge hidden again."

He shook his head.

"Or we can share it."

Atine smiled.

"That is what our ancestors wanted."

Emeka lifted his storyteller's staff.

"Then I will tell the story."

Eze raised the old drum.

"I will teach the children the old rhythms."

Chioma stepped forward.

“And the elders will teach them the traditions.”

Ngozi placed her hand on Ikenna's shoulder.

“That is how a village remembers.”

Suddenly, the old village drum sounded.

BOOM.

The villagers turned toward the meeting ground.

BOOM.

Children came running.

BOOM.

Everyone gathered beneath the great tree.

Chief Chukwudi looked around at his people.

“For many years, we forgot who we were.”

He raised his voice.

“But today, we remember.”

He pointed toward the wooden sign at the entrance.

“The name of this village is...”

The entire crowd answered together.

“AKANMA!”

The word rolled across the village like thunder.

Ikenna smiled.

For the first time in his life, he understood what his grandmother had meant.

A name was not merely a word.

It was a connection to everyone who had come before you.

Then, from deep within the forest, a bell rang.

GONG.

Ikenna turned.

Nobody else seemed to notice.

He looked at the wooden tablet in his hands.

A new sentence had appeared beneath **REMEMBER. SHARE. TEACH.**

“ONE LAST MEMORY REMAINS.”

Ikenna's smile disappeared.

The village had remembered its name.

But somewhere beyond the hills...

something was still waiting to be remembered.

The Village That Remembered

The next morning, Akanma felt different.

For the first time in many years, the village seemed to know itself.

Children gathered beneath the great tree while the elders brought out old baskets, drums, tools, cloth and wooden tablets that had been hidden away in houses.

Emeka sat in the centre of the gathering.

“Today,” he announced, “we will tell the story properly.”

And he began.

He told them about the first settlers.

He told them about the twelve Keepers.

He told them about Atiah and the terrible mistake he had made.

He told them how fear had caused people to hide their own history.

The children listened carefully.

Some asked questions.

Some laughed at the lighter parts.

Others became quiet when they heard about the people who had forgotten their families and traditions.

Ikenna sat beside Ngozi.

“Grandmother,” he asked, “will we ever forget again?”

Ngozi smiled.

“We might forget small things.”

She pointed toward the children.

“But if we teach them, they can remind us.”

Atine nodded.

“That is why memory should never belong to one person.”

Across the gathering, Awini stood quietly.

Chief Chukwudi approached him.

"You have much to answer for."

Awini lowered his head.

"I know."

"But you also have something to give."

Awini looked up.

"My knowledge?"

"Your knowledge, your experience and your mistakes."

The chief placed a hand on his shoulder.

"Teach the younger generation what you learned."

Awini nodded.

"I will."

Then Abanga stepped forward.

"I must leave."

Ikenna looked at him.

"Where will you go?"

Abanga looked toward the eastern hills.

"There are other places."

"Other villages?"

"Perhaps."

He smiled faintly.

"Other people may have forgotten their stories too."

Ikenna understood.

Abanga had spent years running from his past.

Now he was going to help others face theirs.

Before leaving, he handed Ikenna the bronze bell.

“Keep it safe.”

Ikenna accepted it.

“But I'm not a Keeper.”

Abanga smiled.

“Neither am I.”

He turned and walked toward the forest.

Ikenna watched until he disappeared among the trees.

That evening, the village gathered for a celebration.

The drums played.

The elders told stories.

The children danced.

And for the first time, everyone proudly spoke the name that had almost disappeared.

Akanma.

Later that night, Ikenna stood alone beneath the great tree.

He looked at the bronze bell.

Then he heard it.

GONG.

He turned toward the eastern hills.

Another bell answered.

GONG.

Then a third.

Farther away.

GONG.

Ikenna smiled.

He finally understood the message.

The story of Akanma was not ending.

It was beginning again.

He lifted the bell and whispered:

“We remember.”

The wind moved gently through the leaves.

And somewhere beyond the hills, something answered.

GONG.

THE END

LIFE LESSONS

1. Never Forget Where You Come From

Knowing your history helps you understand your identity and where you belong.

2. Knowledge Should Be Shared

Knowledge becomes more valuable when it is responsibly passed from one generation to another.

3. Fear Can Lead to Wrong Decisions

Atiah believed he was protecting his people, but fear led him to make a terrible choice.

4. Learn From the Past

History can teach us how to avoid repeating the mistakes of those who came before us.

5. No One Person Should Control Everyone's Story

A community's history belongs to everyone, not just one person.

6. Courage Means Facing Difficult Truths

Ikenna and his friends continued searching even when they were afraid.

7. Unity Makes a Community Strong

Akanma became stronger when its people decided to remember and preserve their history together.

8. Admitting Your Mistakes Is a Sign of Strength

Awini eventually admitted that his desire for control had been wrong.

9. Curiosity Can Lead to Discovery

Ikenna's questions helped uncover a mystery that had been hidden for generations.

10. Stories Keep Culture Alive

When people continue telling their stories, traditions and memories can survive for generations.

QUESTIONS ABOUT THE STORY

A. Comprehension Questions

1. What unusual event happened at the beginning of the story?
2. What happened to the name on the village sign?
3. Who was Abanga?
4. What did the villagers discover in the forest?
5. What was the forgotten name of the village?
6. What did the name Akanma mean?
7. Who was Atiah?
8. Why did Atiah hide the village's history?
9. What were the twelve Keepers?
10. What did Awini want to obtain from the hidden chamber?
11. Why did Abanga feel guilty?
12. What was written on the wooden tablet?
13. Why did Ikenna believe that history should be shared?
14. How did the villagers restore their identity?
15. What did the final bell suggest at the end of the story?

B. Thinking & Discussion Questions

1. Was Atiah completely evil, or was he motivated by fear?
2. Do you think Atiah was right to hide the village's history? Why?
3. What would you have done if you were Ikenna?
4. Why is it important for young people to learn about their history?
5. What does the story teach us about fear?
6. Why do you think the mysterious bells were important?

7. What does the idea that history belongs to everyone mean to you?
8. How did Ikenna demonstrate leadership?
9. Which character impressed you most, and why?
10. What do you think the final bell represented?

PROVERBS, IDIOMS & THEIR MEANINGS

Proverbs

1. "A people without their history are like a tree without roots."

A community needs to know its history and origins to understand its identity.

2. "What is remembered by many can live forever."

Shared knowledge and memories can survive from one generation to another.

3. "A story lives when someone is willing to tell it."

Stories and traditions survive when people continue passing them on.

4. "You cannot build tomorrow by forgetting yesterday."

The past can teach us important lessons for the future.

Idioms

5. "A bitter pill to swallow"

Something difficult or unpleasant to accept.

6. "In the dark"

To be unaware of important information.

7. "The truth came to light."

Something hidden became known.

8. "A turning point"

A moment when an important change begins.

9. "To bury the past"

To try to forget or hide something that happened before.

10. "Stand together"

To remain united when facing difficulties.

AUTHOR'S NOTE

The Village That Forgot Its Name is a story about memory, identity, courage and the importance of knowing where we come from.

Through Ikenna's journey, the story reminds us that history is not simply a collection of old events. It is the foundation upon which communities build their future.

The people of Akanma nearly lost their identity because their history was hidden from them. Yet they discovered that the strongest way to preserve their story was not to place it in the hands of one person, but to share it with everyone.

May this story encourage every reader to ask questions, learn from the past, respect the stories of their elders and help preserve the history of their own community.

Because when people remember together, their story can live forever.

— The Author